NEW WORLD MONKEYS

An illustrated field guide to 16 distinctive groups

New World monkeys (infraorder Platyrrhini) are native to Central and South America. This guide covers 16 representative kinds—not every species—and summarizes appearance, behavior, size, distinctive traits, habitat, and diet. Measurements are approximate and vary by species, sex, and population.

Photo note: This downloadable version provides three curated photo-gallery links per monkey (close-up, full-body, and habitat/behavior views) rather than embedding third-party photographs. The links open image results so you can view different examples; photo reuse rights vary by image.

At a glance

- **Capuchin monkeys** — Cebus and Sapajus
- **Spider monkeys** — Ateles
- **Howler monkeys** — Alouatta
- **Squirrel monkeys** — Saimiri
- **Common and other marmosets** — Callithrix and Mico
- **Pygmy marmoset** — Cebuella
- **Lion tamarins** — Leontopithecus
- **Tamarins** — Saguinus
- **Uakaris** — Cacajao
- **Titi monkeys** — Plecturocebus, Callicebus, and Cheracebus
- **Night (owl) monkeys** — Aotus
- **Woolly monkeys** — Lagothrix
- **Muriquis (woolly spider monkeys)** — Brachyteles
- **Saki monkeys** — Pithecia
- **Bearded sakis** — Chiropotes
- **Goeldi's monkey** — Callimico goeldii

1. Capuchin monkeys

Scientific group: Cebus and Sapajus

Appearance: Small-to-medium monkeys with expressive faces, dexterous hands, and a long tail. Coat colors vary by species; many have contrasting dark cap-like markings on the head.

Behavior: Curious and exploratory, living in social groups. Some species use tools, including stones to crack hard nuts, and learn by observing others.

Typical size: Typically about 1.3–4 kg (3–9 lb), depending on species; body length roughly 30–56 cm (12–22 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Highly manipulative hands and flexible problem-solving. Some capuchins have partially prehensile tails, but they do not use them as a full weight-bearing fifth limb in the way spider monkeys do.

Habitat and range: Forests, woodland, and sometimes mangrove or seasonally dry habitats in Central and South America.

Eating habits: Omnivorous: fruit, seeds, nuts, insects, eggs, and small vertebrates; diet varies with season and habitat.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





2. Spider monkeys

Scientific group: Ateles

Appearance: Slender body, very long arms and legs, a small head, and a long prehensile tail with a gripping underside. Color ranges from black and brown to golden or reddish.

Behavior: Travel high in the canopy, swinging between branches and gathering in flexible subgroups. Social parties often split up and reunite.

Typical size: Usually around 6–9 kg (13–20 lb); body length about 35–66 cm (14–26 in), with a much longer tail.

Distinctive attributes: The tail acts like an extra hand. The thumb is greatly reduced or absent, creating a hook-like hand suited to suspensory movement.

Habitat and range: Tropical forests from southern Mexico through Central America and much of northern and central South America, depending on species.

Eating habits: Primarily fruit; also leaves, flowers, seeds, and occasionally insects or other animal matter.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





3. Howler monkeys

Scientific group: Alouatta

Appearance: Stocky, shaggy monkeys with broad jaws, a large throat region, and a strong prehensile tail. Coat color varies by species and sex.

Behavior: Often rest for long periods and move deliberately through trees. Groups use loud calls to communicate location and territorial presence.

Typical size: Many species weigh roughly 4–10 kg (9–22 lb); body length often 40–70 cm (16–28 in), plus tail.

Distinctive attributes: Among the loudest land animals. An enlarged hyoid bone and vocal apparatus help produce far-carrying roars.

Habitat and range: A range of tropical and subtropical forests, including rainforests, dry forests, and gallery forests from Mexico to South America.

Eating habits: Leaf-heavy diet, supplemented by fruit, flowers, and buds. Fermenting leaves require a specialized digestive system.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior







4. Squirrel monkeys

Scientific group: Saimiri

Appearance: Small, agile monkeys with short muzzles, large eyes, gray-olive backs, pale undersides, and a long non-prehensile tail.

Behavior: Active, quick-moving, and social; often forage in large groups and move rapidly through the lower and middle forest canopy.

Typical size: Usually about 0.5–1.1 kg (1.1–2.4 lb); body length around 25–35 cm (10–14 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Their facial markings often create a pale mask around the eyes and muzzle. The tail helps balance but cannot grasp branches.

Habitat and range: Tropical forests, river-edge forests, and seasonally flooded woodlands in Central and South America, varying by species.

Eating habits: Insects and other small animals, fruit, and sometimes flowers, nectar, or seeds.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





5. Common and other marmosets

Scientific group: Callithrix and Mico

Appearance: Small monkeys with dense fur, claw-like nails on most digits, and often prominent ear tufts. Color patterns vary widely by species.

Behavior: Live in family-based groups; twins are common in many species, and group members often help carry and care for infants. They cling to trunks and leap among branches.

Typical size: Often around 0.3–0.5 kg (0.7–1.1 lb); body length roughly 18–25 cm (7–10 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Many marmosets are specialized for gouging tree bark to obtain gum and sap. Their nails and teeth support this feeding style.

Habitat and range: Mostly forests and woodland in eastern and Amazonian Brazil, with species-specific ranges.

Eating habits: Tree gums and sap, fruit, insects, and other small prey; the proportions depend on species and season.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior



6. Pygmy marmoset

Scientific group: Cebuella

Appearance: Tiny, brownish-gold monkey with fine streaked fur, a rounded head, and a long tail used for balance.

Behavior: Moves along trunks and branches, often clinging vertically to tree bark. Usually lives in small family groups.

Typical size: Among the smallest monkeys: about 100–150 g (3.5–5.3 oz); body length around 12–16 cm (5–6 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Specialized lower incisors help gouge bark so the animal can feed on tree exudates. The tail is long but not prehensile.

Habitat and range: Western Amazon Basin, especially river-edge and seasonally flooded forests in parts of Brazil, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, and Bolivia.

Eating habits: Tree gum and sap are central foods; also insects, fruit, and other small invertebrates.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior



7. Lion tamarins

Scientific group: Leontopithecus

Appearance: Small monkeys with long, silky coats forming a mane around the face. Golden lion tamarins are orange-gold; other species have black, golden-headed, or mixed coats.

Behavior: Active forest foragers that search crevices and bromeliads for insects and small prey. Family groups often cooperate in infant care.

Typical size: Generally around 0.5–0.8 kg (1.1–1.8 lb); body length roughly 20–34 cm (8–13 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: The mane frames the face like a miniature lion. Several species are highly threatened because of habitat loss and fragmentation.

Habitat and range: Atlantic Forest remnants of southeastern Brazil; each species has a limited range.

Eating habits: Fruit, insects, spiders, small vertebrates, nectar, and other foods found while probing tree holes and vegetation.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





8. Tamarins

Scientific group: Saguinus

Appearance: Small, often strikingly marked monkeys. Some have white crests, mustaches, pale faces, or reddish-brown coats; features differ greatly among species.

Behavior: Usually live in small social groups and forage actively through the understory. Many species show cooperative care of infants, with adults carrying young.

Typical size: Typically around 0.3–0.7 kg (0.7–1.5 lb); body length often 18–30 cm (7–12 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Their facial hair and head markings can be unusually elaborate. The cotton-top tamarin has a dramatic white crest.

Habitat and range: Tropical forests of Central America and northern and western South America, depending on species.

Eating habits: Fruit, insects, nectar, tree exudates, and occasionally small vertebrates.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





9. Uakaris

Scientific group: Cacajao

Appearance: Medium-sized monkeys with shaggy coats, short tails, and bare faces. The bald uakari is famous for its bright red face; other species differ in color.

Behavior: Travel through flooded and terra firme Amazonian forests, often in large groups. They forage high in trees and may travel long distances in search of fruit.

Typical size: Roughly 2.5–3.5 kg (5.5–7.7 lb) for many adults; body length about 30–55 cm (12–22 in), excluding the short tail.

Distinctive attributes: The short tail is unusual among arboreal New World monkeys. Facial color and coat patterns vary among uakari species.

Habitat and range: Western Amazon Basin, particularly seasonally flooded forests and river islands in Brazil, Peru, and nearby regions.

Eating habits: Fruit, seeds, and other plant foods; some species can process hard seeds and unripe fruits.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





10. Titi monkeys

Scientific group: Plecturocebus, Callicebus, and Cheracebus

Appearance: Small-to-medium, furry monkeys with long, often bushy tails. Fur may be red, brown, gray, or black, with contrasting facial or collar markings in some species.

Behavior: Often live in bonded pairs with offspring. Partners sit close together, communicate with calls, and may intertwine their tails while resting.

Typical size: Commonly around 0.8–1.5 kg (1.8–3.3 lb); body length roughly 25–45 cm (10–18 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Strong pair bonds and close partner contact are characteristic of many species. Their long tails are not prehensile.

Habitat and range: Forests and woodland across much of the Amazon Basin and other parts of South America, depending on genus and species.

Eating habits: Primarily fruit and leaves, with flowers, seeds, and small animal prey included in some diets.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





11. Night (owl) monkeys

Scientific group: Aotus

Appearance: Small monkeys with large forward-facing eyes, rounded heads, gray or brown fur, and often pale facial patches.

Behavior: Mostly nocturnal; live in family groups and commonly sleep in tree hollows or dense vegetation during the day. Pairs often share infant care.

Typical size: Usually around 0.7–1.3 kg (1.5–2.9 lb); body length about 24–47 cm (9–19 in), excluding the tail.

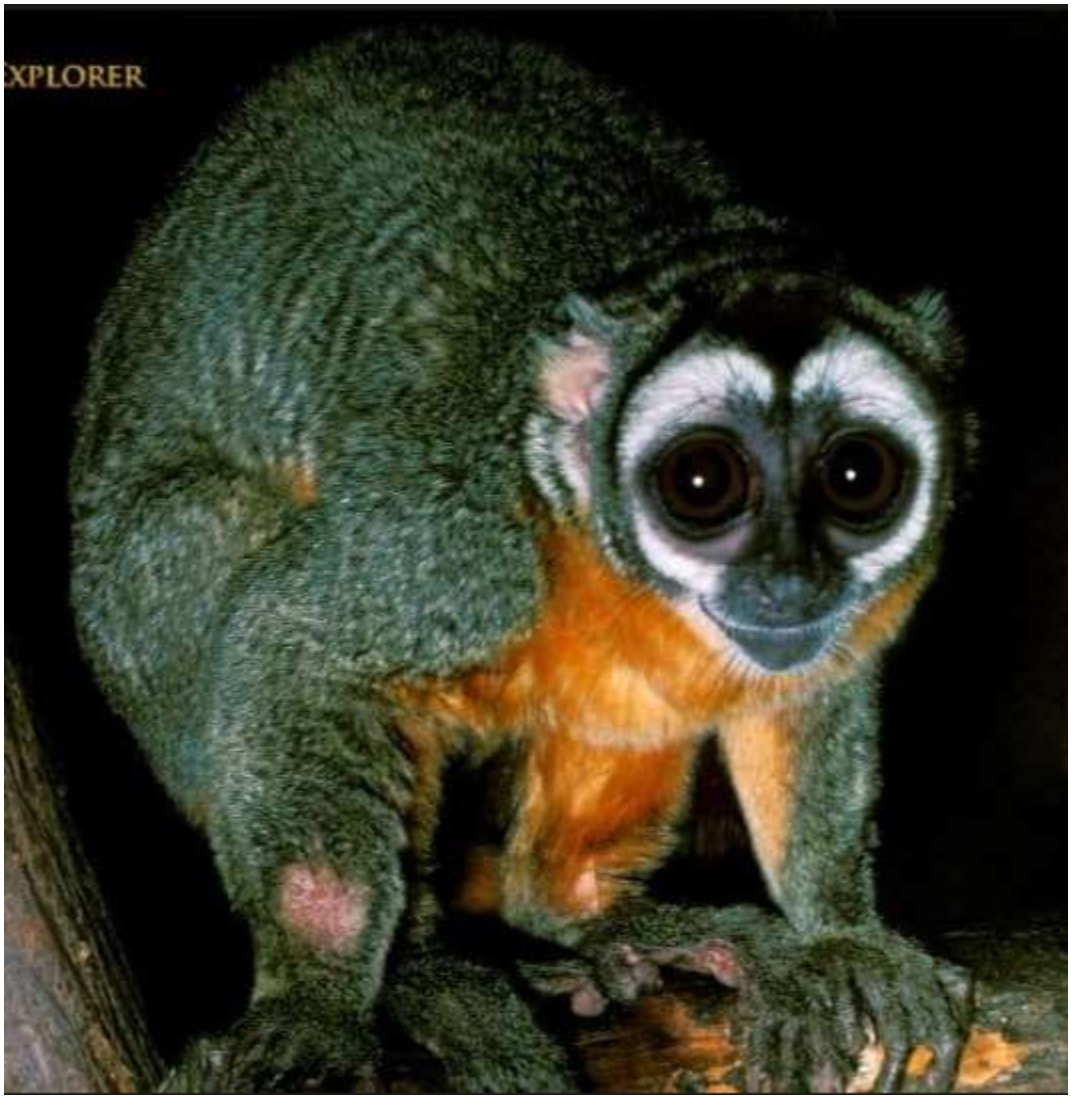
Distinctive attributes: The only living monkeys that are consistently nocturnal. Their large eyes are adapted for seeing in low light.

Habitat and range: Forests from Panama and northern South America through much of the Amazon and adjacent regions; exact range varies by species.

Eating habits: Fruit is important, along with leaves, nectar, insects, and other small animal prey.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





12. Woolly monkeys

Scientific group: Lagothrix

Appearance: Medium-to-large monkeys with dense, woolly fur, rounded heads, strong limbs, and long prehensile tails.

Behavior: Social canopy-dwellers that travel and forage in groups. They use their tails to support themselves while reaching for food.

Typical size: Often about 5–10 kg (11–22 lb); body length around 40–60 cm (16–24 in), plus tail.

Distinctive attributes: Their dense coat and powerful grasping tail distinguish them from many other canopy monkeys.

Habitat and range: Humid tropical forests of the western Amazon and adjacent Andean foothills.

Eating habits: Mostly fruit and leaves, with flowers and occasional seeds or small animal foods.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





13. Muriquis (woolly spider monkeys)

Scientific group: Brachyteles

Appearance: Large, long-limbed monkeys with grayish or brown fur, long prehensile tails, and expressive faces. Adult males may have conspicuous facial coloration.

Behavior: Arboreal and social, moving through forest canopies and often showing relatively tolerant social interactions compared with many primates.

Typical size: Among the largest New World monkeys: commonly around 9–15 kg (20–33 lb); body length about 45–70 cm (18–28 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: They combine long limbs and a prehensile tail with a notably reduced thumb. Both northern and southern muriquis are conservation priorities.

Habitat and range: Atlantic Forest in southeastern Brazil, now fragmented and greatly reduced from its historical extent.

Eating habits: Primarily leaves and fruit, with flowers and other plant matter depending on season.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





14. Saki monkeys

Scientific group: Pithecia

Appearance: Medium-small monkeys with long, shaggy coats and bushy tails. Some species have pale or contrasting faces, especially adult males.

Behavior: Agile leapers that move through the canopy and often occur in pairs or small family groups. They can leap between branches rather than swing like spider monkeys.

Typical size: Often around 1.5–2.5 kg (3.3–5.5 lb); body length roughly 30–50 cm (12–20 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: A fluffy, bushy tail and shaggy facial hair create a distinctive silhouette. Facial color varies by species and sex.

Habitat and range: Rainforests and other wooded habitats across northern and central South America.

Eating habits: Fruit and seeds are important; many species specialize in hard seeds and also eat leaves or insects.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





15. Bearded sakis

Scientific group: Chiropotes

Appearance: Dark, long-haired monkeys with a beard-like growth around the chin and a bushy tail. Some have pale facial markings or a contrasting forehead.

Behavior: Travel in groups through the upper canopy and use powerful jaws and teeth to open hard seeds and fruits.

Typical size: Usually around 2–4 kg (4.4–8.8 lb); body length roughly 32–50 cm (13–20 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Specialized teeth and jaws allow them to exploit hard seeds that many other monkeys cannot easily open.

Habitat and range: Tropical forests of the Guiana Shield and parts of the Amazon region, depending on species.

Eating habits: Seeds, nuts, fruit, and other plant material; some insects may also be eaten.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





16. Goeldi's monkey

Scientific group: Callimico goeldii

Appearance: Small, dark-furred monkey with a mane-like ruff around the head and neck and a long tail.

Behavior: Lives in small groups, forages in dense understory, and may associate with tamarins. Its movements often include climbing and short leaps.

Typical size: About 0.4–0.8 kg (0.9–1.8 lb); body length around 20–30 cm (8–12 in), excluding the tail.

Distinctive attributes: Unlike most marmosets and tamarins, females commonly give birth to a single infant rather than twins. Its classification and relationships have been debated.

Habitat and range: Western Amazonian forests in parts of Brazil, Colombia, Ecuador, Peru, and Bolivia.

Eating habits: Fruit, fungi, insects, and other small invertebrates; fungi are an unusual and notable part of its diet.

Photo galleries: 1. Close-up / face | 2. Full body / markings | 3. Habitat / behavior





How to compare New World monkeys

Tail use is one of the most useful visual clues. Spider monkeys, howler monkeys, woolly monkeys, and muriquis have prehensile tails that can grasp and support the body. Capuchins also have tails that can grasp to varying degrees, while squirrel monkeys, marmosets, tamarins, titis, sakis, and night monkeys use their tails mainly for balance.

Diet and movement often go together. Howler monkeys can live on a leaf-heavy diet and tend to conserve energy; spider monkeys travel widely in search of fruit; marmosets specialize in tree gums and sap; bearded sakis and some sakis are adapted to hard seeds; and night monkeys forage after dark.

Taxonomy and common names change as research develops. Some names in this guide refer to genera or broader groups rather than a single species, so exact measurements, range, and conservation status depend on the species.

Further reading

- University of Wisconsin Primate Info Net — New World monkey image resources
- Nature Education / Scitable — New World monkeys overview
- Smithsonian National Zoo — Animal collection
- Wikimedia Commons — image search